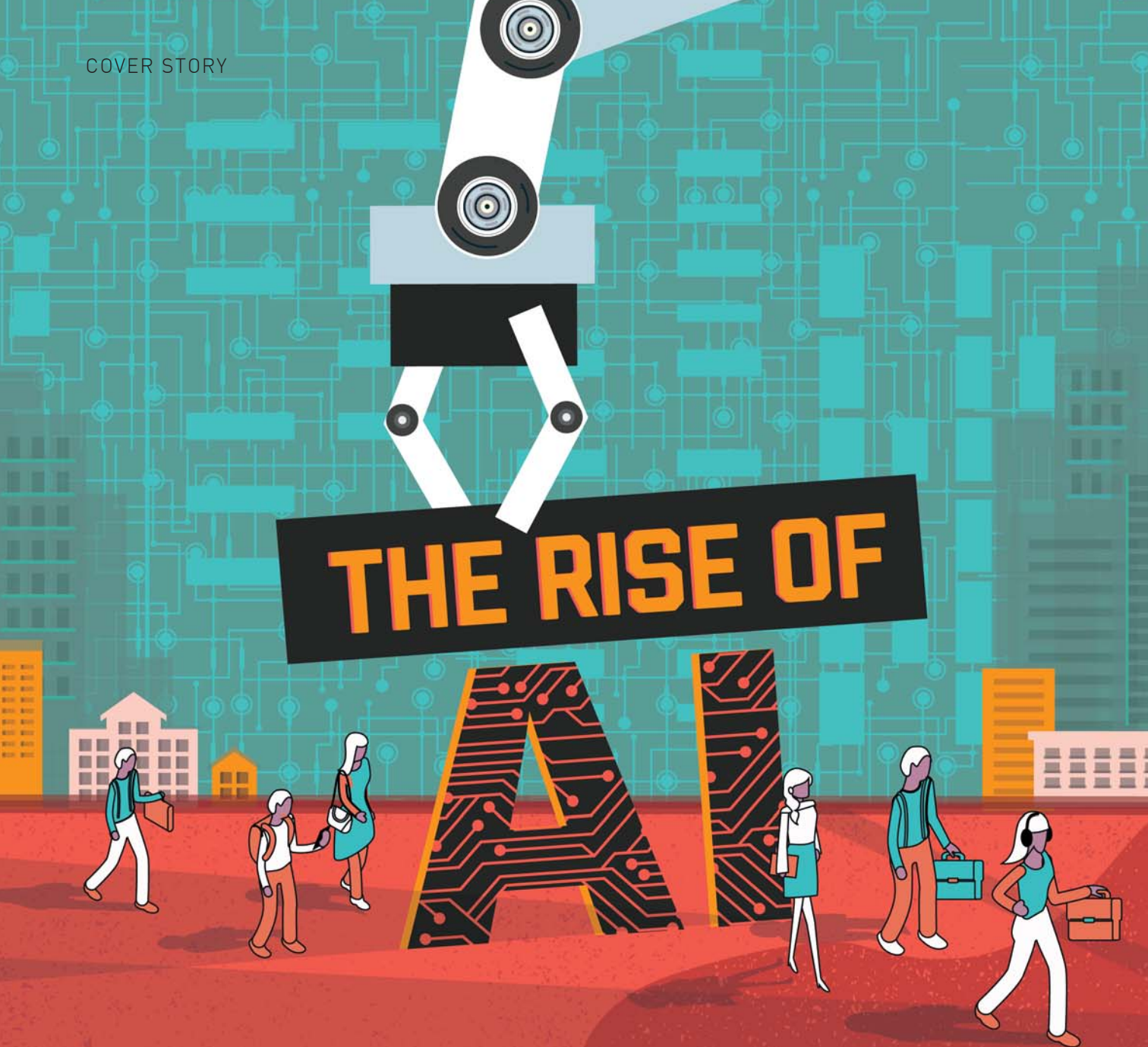




Organisations embracing AI must realise that it is not the jobs that are being automated, but tasks. Therefore, the skills for the now automated tasks are redundant, and, with the new task thus emerging, there is a need to reskill the workforce.

BY S. AJAY KUMAR



In its most refined definition, Artificial Intelligence (henceforth AI) is any machine that displays consciousness and subsequently becomes self-aware, and thereby, works towards self preservation. So, it will be a while before we witness AI, since this warrants the need for quantum computers that are embedded with an architecture beyond bits (1s and 0s). While we cater ourselves to simulated forms of AI in Siri and Alexa, which make extensive use of Machine Learning, predictive technology is at its helm in the consumer space and is redefining user experience in a big way.

However, the fact remains that AI is here to stay in a marked way, and, in effect, is transforming job roles, and, altering human lives like never before. The transformations being brought forth by AI is multi-dimensional. While it definitely makes our lives easy, it is culpable of dissolving the front line and repetitive jobs. The onus is therefore on organisations and HR to analyse the

largescale fallout of AI, in terms redefined work roles, and enacting newer skills and tools and preparing the workforce for newer challenges.

Areas of AI Influence

An important area where HR could actually leverage from AI is Learning and Development. Employee learning always comes with rider. It could either be a case of an employee seeking insights beyond the realm of training, or, another, where the employee is showing latency in a domain that is beyond his scope of work. An AI driven learning tool, can extract employee information from his performance dashboard, identify the gaps that need to be improved, and, thereafter, come forth with a palette of learning capsules that can be facilitated within the organisation.

Another prominent area that shall see greater focus in 2019 and beyond, is the use of AI in enhancing employee experience. Through AI, companies shall overhaul the employee experience from recruitment till employee exit, thus impacting employee engagement, organisational culture, and, employer brand value.

One of the ways of enriching candidate experience is through blind hiring, which is expected to be a HR trend in 2019. AI can be instrumental in eliminating unconscious bias during the process of shortlisting, and thereafter, the interviewing stage. AI can be programmed to eliminate bias by way of bypassing information such as names, places, past organisations worked and so on. Though, decisions related to hiring lies in human hands, the fact that there are checks and balances in place to overcome biases helps an organisation to a large extent.

Machine Learning, an AI extension, is conspicuous in its usage for pattern identification and subsequent decision-making, and thereby, diluting human intervention, while delivering results in a limited time span and with superior efficiency. AI can further be made to learn to generate automated responses to employee queries, and, thus, isolate HR personnel from an otherwise mundane and time-consuming task, and, renew their focus towards tasks that demand larger attention.

Another AI application that is in

The 8 Ways HR Can Use Artificial Intelligence

Streamline Your Hiring Process

1. Algorithm-Based Screening To Automatically Segment, Advance (Or Decline) Applicants
2. Predictive Analytics To Determine Performance Potential
3. Automate Admin Tasks Such As: Coordinating Available Time Off In The Schedule, Filtering And Organizing Employee Data And Reports, Or Migrating Data From One Vendor's System To Another

Protect Your Company And Employees From False Accusations

4. Monitor Employee Compensation For Discrepancies Based On Protected Categories.
5. Documenting Performance Reviews And Employee Behaviour And Productivity
6. Quickly Identify Suspicious Employee Activity And Launch Accurate And Unbiased Investigations Based On Data

Improve Performance And Retention

7. Find Opportunities For Improvement And Recommend Appropriate Training For Customer Support Or Sales Representatives
8. Identify Disengaged Employees

(Source: balancepointpayroll.com)

SKILLS FOR FUTURE

Complex Problem Solving
Critical Thinking
Creativity
People Management
Emotional Intelligence
Relationship Making
Negotiation
Cognitive Flexibility

Logging & Reporting
Administrative
Physical Labor
Predictable Analysis
Quality Control
Calibration
Driving or Riding
Information Gathering

SKILLS AT RISK

Source: digitalhrtech.com)

vogue is the Applicant Tracking System (ATS). While ATS has apparently reduced HR effort in scanning and short-listing resumes and selection of candidates, it needs to be worked upon in terms of making available the best suited resumes for the job in question, and, also overcome hiring biases.

A study by Deloitte has revealed that even though more than seventy percent respondent organisations have admitted that AI is critical for their business, only a third were prepared with the AI framework required for their business. This translates to the workforce being unprepared for the after-effects of digital transformation and AI on their respective job roles. Therefore, as a strategic business partner, HR needs to ponder over the impact of AI on the workforce and derive an action plan to tackle the same.

Redefining tasks, not jobs

Organisations embracing AI must realise that it is not jobs that are being automated, but tasks. Therefore, the skills for the now automated tasks are redundant, and, with the new task thus emerging, there is a need to reskill the workforce. Organisations need to realise that automated job roles make way for job transformation rather than elimination.

Hence, it is prudent for HR to educate oneself about AI, and, thereby dispel myths and be cognisant and far-sighted over its wide-ranging implications on the business landscape.

At the same time, it is invariable to take stock of the prevalent job roles in the workplace, and, brainstorm with the various business heads on the newer roles that need to be automated, and fast. This will give a panoramic view of the job roles that shall be automated, the time-span involved, and, the required steadfastness to prepare the workforce on those very lines.

AI also brings forth a wide array of platforms such as chatbots and other automated tools for employee interaction. It becomes the wisened duty of HR to utilise these manifests to the maximum to introduce efficiency and swiftness in response, while at the same time, ensuring that employee empathy is given due credence.

The era of wearable tech and IoT

In an era where wearable gadgets and tech is the in thing for employee performance, it also generates an abundance of hitherto unknown and therefore beyond reach data for HR as well as the business leads. Pruning the AI in the right direction will ensure that these tech tools are efficiently utilised, and, at the same time, enforce greater efficiency within the organisation.

With Internet of Things (IoT) knocking fervently at our doors, time has come for HR to tap employee sentiment from their very phones, and, make use of AI/ML derived solutions to identify areas where employees are satisfied or struggling, and, ensure that the areas of concern are redressed, and, thus, invigorate a sense of belonging among the employee population.

Human Capital reached out to HR spokespersons from various industry segments to understand the impact of the rise of AI in their respective industry, and, the manner in which the sector/organisation is preparing itself to the challenges that AI has thus brought forth.

Source:
talenttalks.net
cornerstoneondemand.com
learn.g2crowd.com
thehrx.com
people-doc.com
crowdstaffing.com

“Through AI, companies shall overhaul the employee experience from recruitment till employee exit, thus impacting employee engagement, organisational culture, and employer brand value.”

AUTOMOTIVE

Constant upskilling, change management, awareness building, are all key necessities that HR will need to focus out here.

What was once sci fi, is today in our homes and workplaces. Technology is revolutionising the way we live, do things, and even think. This is exciting for any industry, because organizations are constantly looking for ways to improve efficiency and effectiveness. For instance, Continental is on its way to become an AI-empowered company globally, and HR is an enabler to support, empower and educate.

AI for automating mobility: AI has a large role to play for safe and efficient mobility in the future. Most visible progress using AI may be seen in the field of advanced driver assistance systems (ADAS). AI will allow vehicle systems to recognise pedestrians and cyclists as well as their gestures and intentions with much greater precision and reliability. This will reduce the potential number of false alarms, and, an increased acceptance of corresponding systems. They can also recognise the presence of a pedestrian even if almost completely hidden from view behind a parked delivery vehicle. And, in time, notice whether pedestrians are actually watching the traffic carefully or are being distracted by their smartphones.

This implies having a good talent pipeline, hiring right and building expertise. Continental's in-house R&D centre in Bangalore, Technical Centre India (TCI), is home to experts working on different AI areas such as Machine Learning, Computer Vision, Biometrics, and Robotics. IIT Madras with its known capability in machine learning and bio-inspired neural networks will contribute to Continental's ADAS business that provide drivers and passengers with additional safety and an increase in comfort.

AI to make our employees work easier: In process automation, AI will make our employees' work easier. Monotonous tasks can be further automated and relevant information from a huge volume of data will be more identifiable. A simple example would be using AI to sieve out the right candidate for a job-role from a pool of data. There are several aspects of the recruitment process that can be simplified using AI. There are work-in-progress projects currently within HR, which, when complete, would become good case studies for AI in HR functions. I personally believe that in this age of disruptive technologies, we need to look at every opportunity to accelerate AI and human interactions. This should go beyond data. For instance, how can AI help HR professionals in strategic decision making?

AI for manufacturing excellence: Industry 4.0 readiness is a Continental priority globally, and, AI has a huge role to play here. Continental India too is upgrading to Industry 4.0 to ensure smarter, more efficient

production processes and practices. Our Central Electronics Plant, Bangalore has deployed Collaborative Robot (COBOT), to work in a human-machine team environment. Unlike traditional industrial robots, COBOT works hand-in-hand with operators, sharing mutual work spaces. It assists with complex, repetitive tasks, relieving operators to focus on more precision jobs and quality aspects of production. Constant upskilling, change management, awareness building, are all key necessities that HR will need to focus out here.



AJAY KUMAR

Head - HR, Continental India

BEAUTY AND WELLNESS

New-age automation technologies are penetrating all spheres and processes of the modern economy and corporate world with a profound impact, and at a global level.

New-age automation technologies that are digital and disruptive in nature are penetrating all spheres and processes of the modern economy and corporate world with a profound impact, and at a global level. The function of Human Resources too, has definitely undergone a paradigm shift in tune with the pace of technological changes, in contrast to what it was several years ago. In this context, a set of challenges and opportunities await the profession.

Status Quo of the HR function

As per the 2018 Deloitte Human Capital Trends report, the implementation of technologies such as automation, robotics and AI is increasing at an unprecedented rate. In the survey, 41% of the respondents gave this topic utmost priority. Approximately, half of the respondents mentioned that their organisations are deeply engaged in automation-related projects, with 24% using AI and robotics to undertake routine tasks, 16% to augment human skills, and, 7% to restructure work completely. The report further points out that AI and robotics are presenting exciting new capabilities for HR. Software has evolved to the extent that it is now recognising faces and identifying gender, listening to voices and understanding moods, decoding video interviews to analyse education levels, lying and cognitive ability. Analytic tools have proved their brilliance by diligently selecting candidates, evaluating employees' career options and training managers for the cause of improving their leadership skills. In the face of these developments, HR as a function will need to cautiously take a stock of the situation by understanding the skills necessitated by an organisation, and, how it plans to add value to the organisation before it ventures into the arena of AI.



PRANAV JYOTI

Global Head of HR Operations
& People Analytics, VLCC

AI as a Strategic Partner to HR

Business leaders and HR executives strongly opine that merging AI into HR functions including induction of employees and administration of benefits will certainly result in improvement of overall employee experience. IBM in 2017, conducted a survey among 6000 executives, "Extending expertise: How cognitive computing is transforming HR and the employee experience," where a majority 66% of CEOs firmly say that cognitive computing possesses the potential to transform strategic dimensions of HR. Again, 54% HR executives believe that cognitive computing will impact critical roles within the HR department.

Odds against AI in HR

In 2017, the Human Resources Professional Association (HRPA) stated in a survey that 52% of respondents disclosed that their businesses were not intending to adopt AI in their HR departments in the next five years. Around 36% cited that their company was too small in size to do so, while 28% mentioned their senior leadership did not see the rationale for such technology.

AI in HR is a given, and, human beings need to ensure that AI tools & techniques are properly used by them to ensure optimal effectiveness.

AI has been prevalent for years, and, has been quietly transforming our lives. The investment in AI in the last 40-50 years has resulted in intelligent machines with high cognitive capabilities. AI has the potential to disrupt our world and the way we live. Though there is a lot of hype around AI today, with numerous companies working the market for the use of AI in HR, the market for AI applications for HR is still in its nascent stage.

The current focus of AI in HR is more around automation as companies look at decreasing costs and increasing efficiencies through improved accuracy. E.g. basic AI has also been used in keyword searches in CVs to shortlist the required skill sets. As companies gain expertise in the short-term in automation, the focus will shift towards better predictions especially in recruitment. In the long-term, we can expect HR to significantly invest in robotics and independent decision making.



KUHUKEKA GHOSH
Business Manager-HR
FIA Technology

In the fintech space, with distributed agent network in resource poor settings, AI in recruitment will be particularly useful to minimise frauds. Chatbots in varying forms have been the visible application of AI in financial services. However, there is a concerted effort in using machine learning to various aspects of risk.

In a distributed agent network, "right" sourcing is very critical to the success of the model. Maximising the use of local talent for agent hiring is critical to long-term sustainability of the industry. Local hires understand customers better, and, customers are more comfortable interacting with them. There is a natural trust between them that is critical for the sustainability of the business model. However, there are no methods to identify fraudulent agents. During recruitment of agents, companies currently rely on the gut feel of the field level staff who do the sourcing. Even if there are scoring models which are used to rank the agents, most of the time the decision is left to the subjective judgement of the field executive. In regular recruiting, most hiring decisions are made in the first 60 seconds of meeting the candidate. Candidates also go through multiple levels of screening including behavioural assessment before the final decision is made. In case of agent selection, especially for the last mile, companies cannot afford to have a layered selection process since margins in this business are very low. Leaving the selection to the subjective assessment of the field staff can lead to fraudulent agents entering the system increasing the risk of the system. This is where AI algorithms in recruitment can play a huge role. Using AI algorithms, one can weed out high risk profiles, assess customer orientation, and, training needs, using gamification techniques. However, we also need to be cognisant of the algorithm biases that can creep in and lead to selection bias. One thing is certain- AI in HR is a given. Human beings need to ensure that AI tools & techniques are properly used by them to ensure optimal effectiveness.

We are heading to a point where human-machine partnership will be a good combination. And, it will be the HR department's responsibility to ensure that Humans and machines complement each other.

As per World Bank projections, we are going to add \$2.5 trillion to the global GDP in 2018. The scale of growth has changed, as also that of the processes. As we move towards the future, we are needed to be even more nimble. Everyone from customers to employees require shorter turnaround time for processes. Sometimes, even shorter than humanly possible. This is precisely where digital technology and AI step into the picture.

Through AI, we can automate individual processes with intense precision. It is able to self-analyse wide ranging complications and find solutions to them using relevant data sets. This automated system, moreover, learns by itself, and draws key takeaways from the result of every process managed - including the usual results, those that turn out to be success stories, and, even those that end in disappointments. It then correlates various factors that directly or indirectly led to 'that' particular outcome and enhances its overall methodology. Therefore, it rarely adopts a flawed approach. If it does, it ensures that such error or unreliable methodology never gets repeated.

This characteristic of the AI technology is worth its weight in gold, especially in the Finance Sector, which is known for its dynamism. By leveraging the technology, we can ensure that efficiency, effectiveness, and precision are maintained for across-the-board processes. We can also do away with repetitive and fatigue causing tasks that are ultimately prone to errors and omissions.

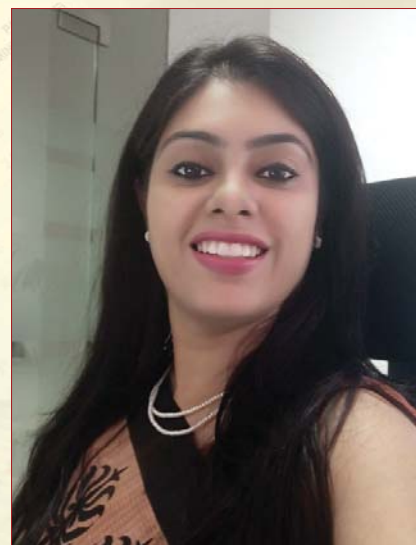
Relevance to the HR department

Against the popular belief, HR department's responsibilities go way beyond overseeing recruitments, managing payroll, resolving grievances, and, conducting events. They are directly responsible for building capacity, ensuring productivity, and, collaborating with the management to generate positive results. They are the ones that convert a company's human resources into the very 'business resources' that help drive greater efficiency.

AI is soon going to gain a more prominent role across all global organisations. Analysts at Gartner have forecasted that more than 85% of customer interactions will be managed without any human interference by 2020. This is the next logical step for business organisations and will ensure that the increasing scale of growth will be sustained. With it, we will be able to free our human resources from time-consuming, repetitive, and, complicated tasks and use them where their expertise is better needed. E.g. It would be more productive to do it via an automated system and then let the loan officer check if individual steps have been implemented correctly.

Surely, we are heading towards an era where human-machine partnership will turn out to be a good combination. And, it will be the HR department's responsibility to ensure that Humans and machines complement each other. With AI, workforce assessments, optimisation of work flows, screening, talent tracking, and applications can be managed via predictive analysis and automation.

It is also important to note that the jobs of tomorrow are going to be very different than they are today. This will require more dynamic resource and skill planning as, according to the World Economic Forum (WEF), one-third of the skill sets required for today's jobs will be entirely new. It also forecasts that 65% of children who are today entering primary school will be employed for those jobs that don't even exist today!



DEEPA ARORA
Head - HR, CoinTribe

HEALTHCARE

The integration of AI in healthcare is not to be seen as elimination of humans from healthcare, since it is meant help the healthcare professionals become better.

The use of AI in healthcare and Internet of Medical Things (IoMT) is in, and, there are several technology apps and solutions that aid in proactive management of a healthy lifestyle. When it comes to healthcare, people still have their inhibitions about AI being able to improve outcomes, in terms of life expectancy. These are owing to reservations over data privacy, carelessness due to lack of human supervision. However, with times, AI is getting sophisticated, and, has gained capabilities of almost doing everything that humans do. Using machine intelligence, a diagnostician can go through an exponential number of samples and the chances of error are almost non-existent. Owing to its constant evolution, and, the ability to make humans better, AI has a lot of potential in healthcare, and, is increasingly becoming a part of our healthcare ecosystem.

With heaps of data being accumulated in digitally connected healthcare systems, these systems are goldmines of information for medical professionals. AI analyses Big Data, segregating and collating information, putting them under categories such as disease processes, clinical representations, clinician's notes, reports from a patient's file, medical research publications and clinical trial outcome, making the data more intelligent. This intelligent data can be used by medical practitioners to create an actionable gist. The medical practitioner has to remain, however, to ensure that the end results have a human touch and human experience, two things that can never be replicated. However, not only does the clinician have to teach the machine first, he has to ensure the end results are error-free, given that a machine can never really learn human nuances.

Given the initial conveniences of making data intelligent, AI is now gaining strong footholds in healthcare segment and industry experts are in awe of its computational capabilities. More so, because these systems do not operate on emotions and are capable of performing repetitive tasks and sifting through mammoth sized data, in a matter of seconds. Many healthcare institutions already have AI systems in place with the ability to identify sight-threatening conditions with equal accuracy to human ophthalmologists. Similarly, there are AI algorithms which can scan an X-Ray faster than a medical professional and detect a small tumour or an early onset of pneumonia. Furthermore, AI is able to detect fatal diseases like cancer with more accuracy, and more importantly, in their early stages.

With these advancements of AI into the healthcare segment, the industry is all set to undergo a massive transformation, and, what is noteworthy is the evolving role of all HR in the segment. As AI continues to penetrate deeper into the segment, it adds to the ability of healthcare professionals, and, makes their understanding of a patient's day-to-day pattern and needs them to be more comprehensive. Such detailed perspective of a patient's condition enables them to offer a more complete and all inclusive feedback, guidance, and support to stay healthy.

AI is increasingly being adopted by healthcare institutions as it aids them in enhancing their capabilities and adds value to their services. The integration of AI in healthcare should not be looked down upon as elimination of humans from healthcare, on the contrary, it is meant help the healthcare professionals become better.



ARINDAM HALDAR
CEO, SRL Diagnostics

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

For HR, AI technology is certainly a game changer to build a healthy rapport with the employees who are used to the likes of Alexa and Siri.

HR, in an effort to provide a conducive work environment, has increasingly started looking at modernised approaches to engage employees. Today, the impact of transformative technologies can be felt in almost all walks of work and life, in general. Along with the changes in the technological landscape, employees' expectations are shifting too, and, is accentuated in organisations. Employees in the software services industry are well aware of customer-centric applications and expect similar experiences and engagement levels at work too.

Need for AI-driven employee ecosystem

Now, with more millennials joining the workforce, the perspective towards work is changing. Besides a paycheck, new-age employees look for a purpose, seek personal development that adds fun, and, expect skill enhancement activities. To be precise, today's employees look forward to having the right conditions in the workplace, where they can feel passionate about what they do, and, contribute to the organisational goals and values. For this, the employees need to be engaged continuously in their own terms. This becomes possible only with ecosystems that provide employees with an immersive experience of being in a workplace.

Employee engagement remains the top challenge in the technology industry, given the strong influence of social media and gaming subcultures. For this reason, employee recognition driven by gamification is trending as much as high-touch communication and instant recognition, all focused at getting attention. These can be achieved by using different tools and resources in HR. Being in the software innovation space, we invested in building the Loop, a mobile-based employee communication app, that is powered by our micro-transformation engine, SpotCues. SpotCues can accelerate development of micro-apps using emerging automation technologies like AI and NLP-driven bots. Loop helped us in managing all engagement-related activities at micro and enterprise level, where our workforce is siloed in terms of geography, teams, and functions.

Driven by the success of Loop, we were inspired to come up with Groupe - an extensible employee engagement app that helps enterprises connect their workforce and enjoy increased productivity. Groupe facilitates all types of employee engagement activities in the form of easy-to-use context-sensitive micro-apps that connect the entire workforce through real-time communication and collaboration tools. Further, Groupe helps increase productivity by automating tasks and delivering job-specific information, enabled by AI and chatbots.

With its broadcast feature, one can carry out organisation-wide communications like announcements, employee recognition shout-outs, engagement surveys, and polls. The communication can also be pushed in the form of 'see-first' posts so that employees do not miss out on important matters. On top of it, the platform makes use of chatbots to guide users through these micro-apps, giving them a conversational experience.

One of the vital responsibilities of HR is keeping employees motivated and happy through Employee engagement activities. This, in turn, leads to high productivity and less employee turnover, which in itself is a big cost saving for any organisation. When you look at technology by itself, it may not be meaningful. It depends on business practices and society to identify the potential use cases and manifest it within their environments. For HR, AI technology is certainly a game changer to build a healthy rapport with the employees who are used to the likes of Alexa and Siri. After all, when employees are happy, productivity boosts, which means better people and better software.



ANITHA PRABHAKAR
Director-HR
Pramati Technologies

MANUFACTURING

The digital disruption impacts an organisation and the markets on which it competes and affects the mindset of change.

AI has been changing our lives since the last couple of years, but today, its presence is bigger than ever. This emerging technology brings a fundamental change in the nature of work by enabling man and machine to make decisions together, and, makes us do things we could not do otherwise. The technology improves repetitive, standardized and time-consuming tasks and providing assisted intelligence as in chatbots.

With AI, workforce assessments, optimisation of workflows, screening, talent tracking, and applications can now be managed through predictive analysis and automation. And, HR professionals can now let the machines complete the administrative tasks and focus on putting the "human" back in human resources. This allows HR's role to evolve with a new focus on business, people, and strategy. AI will enhance employee capabilities, the satisfaction felt from delivering quality work and adding superior value, devoting more time to focus on upskilling competencies, productively contributing to workforce, deepened customer management, innovation and management of teams, mainly work on achieving ground-breaking success.

The benefits of AI and automation for HR and the workforce do not come instantly, and is a journey, and, one can see the short-term benefits of this journey in automation, the medium-term benefits in augmentation, and, the long-term benefits in the amplification of human activities. Leaders and HR executives have faith that merging AI into HR functions like on boarding and administration of benefits can and will improve the overall employee experience.

As more individual tasks become automatable, jobs are being redefined and recategorized, and, it is apparent that automation will result in a massive reclassification and rebalancing of work. While some sections of the workforce will lose out, others will be created. Intelligent digitalisation will not only alter the types of jobs available, but also their number and perceived value. By replacing those doing routine, methodical tasks, machines will amplify the comparative advantage of those with problem-solving, leadership, EQ, empathy and creativity skills. Those performing tasks which automation cannot yet crack, become more pivotal - and, this means creativity, imagination, and design skills will be prioritised by employers. AI will offer millennials exciting opportunities to deliver extra ordinary value to their employers and customers.

Organisations differ as much as the data they produce. The digital disruption impacts an organisation and the markets on which it competes. This affects the mindset of change and requires constant adjustments of the transition path and the goals that must be achieved. And yet, the hardest part is that all these changes must be marked by revolution, not evolution. Successful organisations in the digital age use any number of methods to attract and engage top-tier talent. Having a strong brand and progressive culture is naturally a big help here, as is the ability to pay a premium for this talent.

To get the right employees, digital leaders are increasingly adapting to the demands of top talents as these employees seek non-traditional roles, benefits, incentives, rewards, remuneration packages, and workplace environments. Empowerment is absolutely critical to their motivation. Core-talents both inside and outside the organisation must be given ownership over new initiatives and the leeway to improve their workplace experiences.



LOKESH SIKKA
Chief Human Resources
Officer, Onida

AI is changing the way tasks are performed in organisations, where efficiencies can be significantly enhanced through automation and advanced algorithms.

AI, refers to a group of technologies that include machine and deep learning, predictive analytics, process automation, speech recognition, biometrics, and natural language processing. These allow businesses to mine data, generate insights, create operational efficiencies, provide stronger experiences, and, close the gap between information and action in ways that were never possible before. It has enormous power and potential, and can disrupt, innovate, enhance, and, totally transform a business. It has been estimated that AI market will surge to \$47 billion in 2020 from \$8 billion in 2016.

AI is changing the way tasks are performed in organisations, where efficiencies can be significantly enhanced through automation and advanced algorithms. AI signifies the ability of a machine to 'think' based on the inputs of the user onto the same machine. As more data is fed into the processor, the algorithms enable machines to learn, predict, and act - on the basis of algorithms. When the process is refined over a period of time, using large amount of data, the machines can become a powerhouse of speed, accuracy, and consistency - resulting in much higher levels of productivity and reliability.

AI presents an opportunity for HR departments to transform the age-old hiring, assessment and management practices. AI focuses on streamlining HR processes through analytical processing of data, and thereby, not relying on individual observations in the process of recruiting. Managing on boarding of new employees can also be handled through intelligent chatbots who can be programmed to answer FAQs in real-time and take care of the routine work of the HR department.

Few areas where AI is prevalent are recruitment, employee on-boarding, training, engagement etc. Unilever uses AI extensively for hiring of frontline field force, and, quite a few pharma companies are working in this direction. AI tool is able to effectively shortlist the "high match probable" candidates using algorithm based on the well-defined competency set.

The other area is around Employee Experience. On boarding, training, performance management, feedback processes etc. are several touch points where an employee "experiences" the organisational culture. Sometimes, the cumbersome processes and rigid structures around these "processes" could be more stressful than job itself! That poses an opportunity to organisations to simplify the whole set of processes to make it more user-friendly using automation & AI.

We should also keep in mind that a large workforce today comprises of millennials. What they bring to the table is an opportunity to drive innovation, working with AI, ML and technology driven solutions. What companies make out of it, will differentiate between great and not so great ones! It is all up to the leadership of companies. After all, leadership is not about levels and designations, it is about ability to multiply and leverage your resources towards sustainable business growth over a period of time!

I think humans and AI are together more powerful than either of them alone. AI and technology will be a significant enabler of HR processes, but cannot replace all of them. There is solid proof that the investment in AI can pay off-if you adopt the right approach. A Genpact and FORTUNE Knowledge Group survey of 300 senior executives reveals that organisations that deploy AI strategically enjoy advantages ranging from cost reductions and higher productivity to top-line benefits such as increasing revenue and profits, richer customer experiences, and working-capital optimisation.



PREM SINGH
President - Global Human
Resources, Wockhardt Ltd.

RETAIL

To AI or not to AI' may still be the question for many organisations, but, some have already jumped on the bandwagon and are reinventing key aspects of human resources such as employee onboarding and benefits administration or the planning and managing of day to day group benefits. AI remains unbiased and rational throughout the complete lifecycle of an employee. The AI tool can be used as a looking glass to pick the right candidate from a plethora of candidates for an organisation based on merit, skill-set, experience and industry knowledge. This allows the organisation to filter 'superb' candidates from the merely great ones. For instance, at Nexus Malls, AI-based onboarding can make employee transition both seamless and efficient. It can allow a new employee to meet key personnel from different departments, regardless of their location. We can also tailor AI to answer the employee's questions with regard to policy and procedure and scope of the job. HR professionals can use the tool, often called Machine Learning, to set concrete objectives and let employees function in smaller performance areas.

**ROHAN VASWANI**

Chief Human Resources
Officer, Nexus Malls

One of the AI tools being explored is assessments of desired behaviours and skills, such as Gamification. Gamification applies behaviour-motivating techniques from traditional and social games to a non-game environment. The gamification programme looks more like a loyalty programme, supercharged to help achieve real business goals, when it is expanded beyond points, badges, and leader boards. The intent is to implement it in various HR programmes such as Rewards and Recognition, Employee Learning and Employee Assessments. However, given the newness of this technology in India, finding the right solution provider who can offer the product at a reasonable cost with end-to-end solutions linking all the HR programmes is currently a challenge. Besides, given its high cost, reaping ROI in a short period of time for a mid-sized organisation would also pose a challenge.

Another area of AI being exploring is competency-based assessments. These are highly structured interviews with a static list of questions to assess one or more skills that a candidate may possess. The verbatim or transcript of the candidate's answers is recorded during the interview, and post-interview, it is matched against predetermined sets of answers (called Behavioural Indicators) that indicate ideal behaviour relating to the competency. The only challenge we face here is that most of the companies offering these assessments are startups with little experience, and it also requires a huge investment. AI enables HR professionals to improve overall performance results in their organisations and monitor employees more effectively. It offers a scientific objective and an unbiased result while assessing human behaviour. It will also increase the efficiency and credibility of processes and programmes. Going forward, I am confident that Artificial Intelligence will be a game-changer in human resources.

The power of AI could help define the competencies and skills needed for a successful talent strategy today, and, make projections for making organisations future-proof.

For the enormous opportunities being unlocked by AI, that are challenging and inviting in equal measures, the question confronting HR across industries is "are we ready?" Recent research indicates that in the next three to five years, as a result of the large-scale disruptions due to AI and automation, several among the current workforce in the world's largest economies may find the need to be retrained or reskilled. While everyone from CEOs to HR Heads to employees on the ground agree that AI will transform the workplace, the ways and means of unlocking AI's potential to one's advantage while not compromising on the key values that are central to HR as a strategic function for all organisations- big, and small, stands to be a mystery.

Studies indicate that while two-thirds of CEOs are of the opinion that AI will drive significant value in HR, very few Chief Human Resource Officers report that their those skill gaps in data science and machine learning needed to fulfil that potential for AI to be a competitive advantage.

That said, there are specific areas in HR where AI clearly is already a game changer. To begin with, repetitive, time-consuming administrative tasks like screening of resumes and managing associated logistics can be taken over by AI to significantly increase efficiency and accuracy. This will allow recruiters to reassign themselves into more strategic areas such as understanding the cultural fit of potential candidates and cutting down on the recruitment lifecycle. Similarly, responding to the queries by employees, dipping into a knowledge repository can be done with greater efficiency by smart chat bots, thus bringing about the added power of predictive help.

AI will equip HR teams to analyse an organisation's employment history and cultural core, and, tap into external sources to determine key attributes for success in any given role, and thereafter, use the insights to source the most qualified candidates, sans any bias. It can also develop applications that serve as a virtual coach that infers employees' skills, interests, and, expertise to provide personalised advice to pave the path for career advancement in the right direction.

At an organisation level, the power of AI and associated technologies could help define the competencies and skills needed for a successful talent strategy today, and, make projections for making organisations future-proof. AI and advanced analytics backed by Machine Learning capabilities will help guide employees in developing skills and pursuing the right opportunities to grow, steering clear of rudimentary tasks at the lower end of value spectrum. AI can directly help increase productivity, but that requires training, development, and, new ways of working besides the leadership conviction to embrace new technologies with a human-first vision.

While organisations continue to grapple with multiple demands pertaining to digital transformation reinventing their businesses and processes through the application of newer technologies, the biggest barrier to progress lies in identifying and upskilling the right talent, and, it is quite fundamental to remember that wrong people cannot build the right AI.



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TRAVEL & TOURISM

Technology can facilitate to bridge the silos within which employees bind themselves, and, groom a common and connected organisation. AI can build this as a competitive advantage.

Democratisation (of career choices, asset ownership, content availability etc), customisation, voice based tooling and seamless omnichannel experiences are some of the big digital trends visible today, and, active social platforms are also resulting in digital activism and a strong polarization. Other social trends include longer life expectancy, more fragile organisations and moonlighting.

For instance, chat bots can change the entire experience, be it an OTJ challenge, an interpersonal/team issue or a functional issue, the chat bot could be your "mentor". Employing a chat bot as a "buddy" during the onboarding would massively reduce infant attrition. It can positively impact the "employer brand" and help assess the mood of the organisation and, proactively control potential exits. And, given social learning is a key method employed by leading organisations, chat bots fit firmly in this role.



DHIRESH SHARMA

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Capacity Building

Coaching / mentoring may actually see one of the highest impacts of AI. Jobs are getting redefined or automated, and, reskilling is significantly relevant today. With the enormous content freely available on the internet, curating it for each employee is an opportunity that presents itself. Algorithms can be designed to auto-drive an intelligent talent source mix, with stronger assessment reducing costs and turnaround times and increasing effectiveness. Voice based filtering, if not selection, is already at play in India. "Predictive Analytics" tools can be used to calibrate talent performance. Algorithms will help determine the traits that result in superior performance OTJ over 2-4 years, and, drive better informed decisions on selection of candidates as a part of IJP process. With this PI approach, parsing will acquire a new dimension.

"Listen & Nudge"

Listening tools will drive greater consumer intimacy and consequently higher productivity. E.g. Customer Service - email content and voice pitch analysis tools, typical physical flow patterns to changing workspace iconography to suit the "mood" on the day and design more efficient layouts to improve team working and higher cross-pollination. With diffusion of roles in agile and flat organisation, listening tools can identify nuances of roles better, including aspects such as intra-team touch points, frequency and content and relating that to capability growth initiatives. Technology can actually facilitate an open culture, one that breaks silos within which employees tend to work. It can build a common and connected organisation and AI can build this as a competitive advantage.

Despite all of the above opportunities, significant challenges remain - how do we create a business case for strong investments in HR Tech? How do we ensure that takes priority over another investment option? How do we ensure that the custodian of bringing tech into talent development is itself at the forefront of embracing technology? It will ultimately come down to 3 factors. One, senior leadership's view on the role of talent management in the success of the organisation, two, design thinking and prudent risk-taking at play in the organisation, and three, is there a "Technology First" culture internally that aspires to leverage specifically AI and in general technology for growth. Without that mindset, AI, ML etc will only be a passing fad for the company, which a few people will leverage for their annual bonuses but nothing more.

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